

פרשת פקודי [which this year, being an עיבור יאר, has the זכות of having its very own שבת], marks the conclusion of ספר שמות and the completion of the בנין of the משכן. The משכן is built, all of the כלים are in place, and משה רבינו has the task of assembling everything. The greatest of these tasks was placing the לוחות into the ארון and then positioning all of the כלים in their proper places within the משכן, after setting up the קרשים and the יריעות. Once everything was complete, there was גילוי שכינה.

We could say that this is the climax of ספר שמות, but the word "climax," like many terms today, is overused. We tend to think that a climax must be something dramatic, something astounding, a "ta-da" moment. However, there is a deeper reason for calling this not only the conclusion of ספר שמות but also its climax, and we see this from the following vort.

The בעל הטורים points out that in פרשת פקודי, the phrase כָּאֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה' אֶת מֹשֶׁה, or כָּכֵל אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה', appears 18 times. He explains that this is a רמז to the 18 ברכות of עשרה שמונה. What is the connection?

We know that the משכן, and later the המקדש, was the ultimate center of עבודה. In our times of גלות, עבודה שמונה replaces the משכן as our form of עבודה. Just as the climax of ספר שמות is the completion and assembly of the משכן by משה רבינו, so too, each and every day, we have the opportunity to engage in that same עבודה through our תפילה. We should think that our עבודה corresponds to the climactic conclusion of ספר שמות - the completion and the putting together of the משכן by משה רבינו himself, fulfilling the words כָּאֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה' אֶת מֹשֶׁה. If we do that, it will give us a whole new character, a whole new perspective, about what we're able to accomplish. It's not just our little עבודה, not just our little עשרה שמונה. It's exactly the same thing as the עבודה in the המקדש, and we should respect it, we should give thought to it, we shouldn't just race through it, we shouldn't just mumble the words. We should put in a real effort to do עבודה with a full heart and with full כוונה, and in this way be able to accomplish exactly the same thing as was done in this week's פרשה.

